Title page

Does starting age predict who stays? Competition debut and long-term participation in youth track and field

Running head: Debut age and retention in youth athletics

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Ethics: The study analyses competition results registered by the Norwegian Athletics Federation and is not medical or health research as defined by Norway's Health Research Act (Helseforskningsloven §§ 2 and 4), so approval by a Regional Committee for Medical and Health

Research Ethics was not required. Sikt (the Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research) confirmed that the use of the data raises no data-protection concerns. No participants were contacted or recruited, and informed consent was not required. No individual athlete is identified.

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Related manuscripts: Three other studies of the same registry are cited in the manuscript (a relative-age study in press, a competition-volume cohort study under review, and a performance-progression study under review). They use different exposures and samples, and no text or result overlaps with the present manuscript.

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